

Q How important is prior experience in open source in your recruitment process?

If the candidates are good developers, it does not matter if they do not have the experience in open source. We pay less attention to what technology they are using, and more to how good they are as developers. It is more about how well you know algorithms, data structures, and how well you can develop. The language and technology are secondary to that. Once candidates show they know how to program, we go into the language. It is not critical if you do not know PHP or Java—programmers can easily pick up the language.

Q How does the transition to a FOSS professional happen in TutorVista?

Candidates who do not know PHP spend some time learning it. They also learn about our current code base and understand what goes on, what a database looks like, etc. Once that is done, we give them some small issues to solve initially. They gain confidence and soon start growing into productive individuals.

Q Do you provide training to new employees?

We do not provide formal training, but we have introduced a concept called Friday Tech Talks. Every Friday afternoon, someone from the teams makes a presentation on any technical topic ranging from learning Java, how to deploy applications, or how a CDN can help you—topics that are commonly known to people. The idea is to communicate design patterns, algorithms and data structures.

Each employee is also allotted a mentor who is responsible for the employee's growth in the organisation. We have multiple teams and depending on the need, the employee may keep moving across teams. We find it is important to let people know how they are doing as individuals and to be aware that they are growing. To ensure continuity, the mentor comes into the picture. The idea is that you work closely with a mentor to understand how you are doing, as your mentor will coordinate with the other managers and tell you what you can improve upon.

We have two kinds of career ladders—the tech architect and the delivery manager. Depending on what the employee is interested in, the mentor offers guidance with opportunities for growth. If you want to be a tech architect, you should show the aptitude for solving tough technical problems, and for learning more technologies. If you want to be a delivery manager, you need an aptitude for working with people, planning out and handling releases, figuring out how to break an issue into smaller pieces, and we make sure you get exposure to all of that. Mentors try to push you in the right direction.

Q Do you plan to hire more people in the near future?

There are always plans to hire the right people. This is driven by multiple aspects in terms of what kind of opportunities we see. The intensity of hiring may go up or

"We like people who have experience with open source technologies and know how to figure out what to use and where to search for it. We look for logic and how candidates think through a problem to come up with a solution."

down depending on what the requirements are. However, we have not fixed any long-term plans for hiring.

Q Does certification play a role in the candidate's employability?

If we are recruiting for an IT position that requires managing the production servers, then yes. For an IT admin role, a certification is a good way to start but often, I have found that certification is only an indicator that an employee knows the basics. For a developer, certifications do not matter at all in our experience, as it does not play a direct role in day-to-day activities. When you put real world problems before employees, translating the knowledge acquired in the course of getting certified into a working solution still needs fundamental human qualities like being smart, having problem solving skills, etc. A person with these skills but without certification will still be hired.

Q How is open source used at TutorVista to mimic a classroom experience?

Our data centre and back-up data centre are in the US and that is where all the hosting gets done.

This is an online tutoring service, and to mimic a classroom experience, white boards appear on the tutor's and student's screens. These communicate with each other using ejabber—an open source server that essentially implements the Jabber protocol, and is often praised for its scalability and clustering feature.

Q What kind of open source implementations are you considering in the future?

Apart from Wicket, which I mentioned earlier, Grails is another technology we are looking into.

Currently, the white board uses a Flash-based component. We are also trying to figure out how to convert this into an HTML 5 component. The only areas where we are not using open source is the white board (for which we have used a Flash-based component) and audio (for which we use another Adobe product).

Q Do you feel that open source can be used in mission-critical operations?

Yes, one of our main concerns is to make sure the website is accessible 24/7 as we have no offline component. We ensure that there is zero downtime when we deploy new releases. The day our system goes down, it is a big deal because if customers cannot access the website or get tutoring services, they will lose confidence in us and this will cost us. I do not recollect